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The Romance of Youth

AADITYA SHUKLA, *15*
AADI
NEW DELHI
1.6 MN followers

Amazingly, Aaditya Shukla doesn't have a phone...yet. But naturally, the teen who has over a million people hooked to his reels knows how to make optimum use of those belonging to his mother and elder brother Akash. Aadi, as he is known in creatorsphere, has used the device to document his life—preparing for the CBSE boards, hanging out with his friends—that offers a peek into the minds of Generation Alpha. No concerns about his screen time have been raised, for he ain't a bad student. He recently scored 88 per cent in Class 10.

"If I had been doing badly in academics, teachers would have objected," says Aadi. "I'm proof that even while creating content you can study and do other activities." It helps that his content is squeaky clean and his demeanour one of disarming teenage amiability.

Shukla's creativity on Instagram has resulted in him scoring collab deals (SaReGaMa and Domino's, to name just two) and a DM (direct message) from casting director Shanoo Sharma's office, which resulted in a part in the Netflix series *The Railway Men*. "I had no idea one can make money from it," says Shukla, whose first sponsor deal earned him Rs 2,000. That's when he had 10,000 followers. Simple school math suggests a far, far meatier pie now. ■

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popular podcasters, Raj Shamani (10 million YouTube subscribers and growing), as well as having tea made by Dolly Chai Wala (5 million Instagram followers), a Nagpur-based tea-seller known for his flamboyant style and signature way of serving tea.

Indian creators are also going places. At the 2024 Paris Olympics, Instagram dispatched Barkha Singh and Karan Sonawane (@focussedindian) as part of its creator squad to create a buzz for the Games with behind-the-scenes content and engaging videos. At Cannes, you now see more creators than film stars on the red carpet. This year, lifestyle creator Sakshi Sidhwani made waves with her Cannes-do spirit and style.

But Indian curiosity is not restricted to frivolous or "so-bad-it's-good" videos. Thousands of creators are leveraging digital platforms to share content, build communities, inspire change and earn a sustainable livelihood. Santosh Jadhav, a farmer from Karve village in Maharashtra, for instance. Known online as @indianfarmer, he has uploaded 5,000+ videos since 2018 as part of his mission to make farming a "respectable business". "I realised *kheti* [farming] isn't seen as a business. *Paisa milta nahin. Shaadi hogi nahin. Market haath mein hai nahin* (You won't earn money, won't find a girl to marry and the market is not in your hands). Climate is an issue," he says. "Let's change that image. Let's make videos that educate and benefit others." He and co-founder Akash Jadhav are leading the change. It has got them 4.94 million subscribers on YouTube, a production team in Pune and an annual turnover of Rs 1.5 crore in ad revenue and brand deals. Despite his success, Santosh still works in the fields, growing sugarcane, capsicum, cucumbers and more. "Our vision is to encourage sustainable and profitable residue-free farming," he says. The Jadhavs have also pivoted to educational content, launching their first online course—on growing tomatoes—for Rs 2,000.

Show Me the Money

In 2017, one already saw sure signs of evolution, with all the popularity inevitably being leveraged and marketised. That year, Viraj Sheth and Ranveer Allahbadia (@